“critically endangered” species.

Protecting biodiversity

In reality, the five HIPPO threats identified by Wilson are interrelated, and there is generally no single reason why any particular species is endangered. Agricultural development, for example, can not only destroy a habitat, but can also release greenhouse gases into the atmosphere, contributing to air pollution and climate change. More than 80 percent of the species on the IUCN’s Red List are affected by more than one of the five major biodiversity threats.

Biodiversity maintains the health of the ecosystems of the planet. Ecosystems are a delicate balance of living creatures, both plant and animal, as well as the soil, air, and water in which they live. Healthy ecosystems provide resources that sustain human and all other life, improve resilience against natural disasters and human-made shocks, including climate change, and provide recreational, medicinal, and biological resources.

Although the threats to biodiversity from human activity are serious, ways to protect it are being developed. Foremost is a “sustainable” approach to harvesting and agriculture that allows species—such as fish, trees, or crops—to be maintained at a stable level and even increased over time. Official protected status for areas of land, water, and ice can help sustain threatened species, while national and international agreements and negotiations can mitigate the impact of both legal and illegal trade, such as poaching. Public education also helps people better understand their potential impacts on biodiversity and how to protect it for future generations.